

Signals

- It is extremely useful if the OS is able to interrupt a process in a similar way that hardware is able to interrupt the OS.
- Sometimes we may wish to catch an execution error in the program (e.g. divide by zero, segmentation fault) and ensure data is saved before termination.
- Sometimes we require periodic interruption by setting a timer, or may wish to terminate another process.
- Such asynchronous processing is enabled in UNIX OS by the kernel's signalling service, which allow simple signals to be sent between processes (or from a process to itself). These are sometimes referred to as *software interrupts*.
 - To handle a particular signal, a process must explicitly register a signal handler routine (much like an interrupt handler in the OS), otherwise the default action is usually for the process to be terminated.